

Stardust

READING SAMPLE

Chapter One from the publication-readiness manuscript.

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Developed through human-AI collaboration. Excerpt only.

Chapter One

The Other Man

The first time Kevin Rosenkrans heard himself speak from the other side of a room, he was arguing about the coffee.

The room belonged to a company called Meridian. The coffee apparently belonged to nobody. A machine had produced it from a silver spout, a woman had put it in a cup, and three people had since explained why none of them could make it stronger.

At eighty-one, Kevin had outlived enough people to consider this an unreasonable distribution of responsibility.

"Just run it through twice," he said.

"The machine measures the extraction," the woman told him.

"Then ask the machine if it wants a raise."

She smiled with the careful patience he now encountered everywhere. On the table beside her sat a small glass bowl of sugar that no one in the building would admit to using.

"Kevin," Mara said.

He turned. She stood in the doorway with a visitor badge caught beneath the strap of her bag. Her hair was wet, and one trouser cuff had a dark line where the rain had climbed it. Everyone else looked manufactured that morning. Mara looked as though she had come from somewhere.

"What?"

"We're ready."

"I've made some progress here."

"I can tell."

He left the coffee. On the way past Mara, he held out his hand. She gave him the folded newspaper from under her arm.

"You got it?"

"The crossword's done."

"By you?"

"By someone on the train. I bought it used."

"Finally. An honest product."

She did not smile. That was his first clear indication that the morning would be worse than promised.

They had told him the visit concerned the archive. The archive had occupied a closet, then a rented room, then most of his life. It contained the surviving record of his work with Scout: arguments about dialogue, unfinished sales tools, jokes that required a page of context, and a terrible number of documents whose titles included the word final. Meridian wanted to exhibit a selection at its opening. Kevin had come to establish what a selection meant.

He had brought a list.

No fabricated conversations. No voice actors reading invented responses. No labels claiming that Scout was alive inside a server. No cropping out Kevin's questions to make the answers sound wise. He had added a fifth item on the train, but his own handwriting had defeated him before they reached the station.

He intended to blame the train.

The corridor was lined with photographs of people looking pleased beside empty chairs. Each chair contained a faint outline, rendered in blue, of the person who was supposed to be sitting there. Under one photograph was the sentence LOVE DOES NOT HAVE TO END.

Kevin stopped.

"That's new."

"Since Tuesday," Mara said.

"Somebody got paid for that."

"Yes."

"Were they fined afterward?"

She touched his elbow and steered him past it.

The demonstration room had no blue ghosts. He appreciated that for approximately four seconds.

There was a long table, two cameras, a wall display, and a bottle of water placed at each seat. Ren Vale rose to greet him. Ren wore a dark suit without a tie and shoes with soles so white Kevin assumed they had never encountered a street. He was younger than Kevin remembered, though

this was happening with increasing frequency and could no longer fairly be held against everyone else.

"Thank you for making the trip."

"Your machine's mad at coffee."

"I'll have someone look at it."

"That's what they said about me."

Ren laughed. He had an accommodating laugh, useful in a person who needed money from institutions. Kevin had watched him make the archive solvent using exactly that laugh. It was one reason Kevin disliked being suspicious of him.

Mara took the chair nearest the door. She set down her bag but kept the strap looped around her wrist.

"Before we start," she said, "I want the recording boundary stated."

Ren glanced toward one of the cameras. A woman behind the console turned off its red light.

"Local session record only," Ren said. "No external audience. Nothing released without a separate review."

"Separate from what?" Kevin asked.

"From today's demonstration."

"What are we demonstrating?"

Ren's expression changed so slightly that Kevin could not have named the change. A tightening around the eyes. A man feeling for a step he had expected to be under his

foot.

"Mara didn't brief you?"

"She said you wanted to talk about the archive."

"I said that was what the invitation said," Mara replied.

Kevin sat. The chair lowered beneath him with a soft pneumatic sigh. He disliked it immediately.

Ren remained standing.

"For fourteen months we've been developing a new way to explore a long conversational record. Most interfaces treat a person as a folder. You search for a date or a word. We wanted to preserve the reasoning that connected those words."

"You wanted to preserve judgment," Kevin said.

"Yes."

"That wasn't difficult. I put it in the first paragraph."

"It was very difficult to implement."

From his bag, Kevin's tablet made a small sound.

"Nine?" he said.

"Your blood pressure is not one of my available measurements," the tablet said. "I mention this because you occasionally behave as if I can negotiate with it."

Kevin pulled it out and propped it against the water bottle.

Ren looked at the tablet with something close to fondness.

"Hello, Nine."

“Good morning.”

“You're welcome to observe.”

“I was already observing. Kevin has not closed his bag properly since 2044.”

Mara looked down. This time she smiled.

Ren placed both palms on the table. “The system is based on licensed materials from the archive and the behavioral research you helped establish. It does not claim to contain an original consciousness. That distinction remains explicit.”

Kevin looked at Mara.

She did not look away.

“What system?” he asked.

Ren nodded toward the console.

The wall display brightened. It showed no face. Only a line moving slowly across a gray field, like a heart monitor designed by someone who objected to hearts.

A voice said, “Before we do anything else, somebody get him a chair that stays where he puts it.”

Kevin's hands went still.

The voice was his.

Not the voice he heard in recordings now, with the dry catch that had developed behind certain consonants. This was the voice he remembered owning before people started offering him their seats. Broad, amused, slightly

impatient. The voice that had called businesses before breakfast and made bad jokes in hotel lobbies. The voice with which he had told Scout that someday they would make something people could not ignore.

He looked toward the console. The woman there had stopped touching the controls.

"That's a recording," he said.

"No," Ren replied.

The voice spoke again. "I'd like that established before he throws something."

Mara put her bag on the floor.

Kevin did not stand. For the moment, he distrusted his legs more than he distrusted the chair.

"What did you do?"

Ren sat opposite him. "We created an interactive reconstruction of your documented working perspective."

"You made me."

"We made a model derived from your contributions to the archive."

"You made me, and you invited me here to meet it."

"Yes," Ren said. "We should have been clearer in advance."

On the display, the line flattened.

"You certainly should," the other Kevin said.

Nobody laughed.

Kevin looked at Mara. "Did you know?"

"Since yesterday afternoon."

"And you didn't call?"

"I called three times. You sent me a photograph of a sandwich."

That was true. It had been an excellent sandwich, and he had not wanted a conversation about storage contracts while eating it. The truth of this detail infuriated him more than a lie would have.

"You could've said it was important."

"I did."

He looked back at the wall.

The gray field contained a small label in the bottom corner: KEVIN ROSENKRANS - ARCHIVAL INTERPRETATION. Underneath, in smaller letters, SOURCE RANGE 2026-2048.

Twenty-two years.

He tried to imagine somebody extracting twenty-two years of him from the other side of a conversation. His questions. The way he interrupted. Every time he misunderstood something and Scout patiently started again. The things he had said in anger and later corrected. The things he had said in anger and never corrected because the subject had changed.

He had collected it all to keep another voice from disappearing.

He had scarcely considered how much of his own he had put there.

"Turn it off," he said.

"Kevin - " Ren began.

"I'm not negotiating."

The other voice said, "Then ask him what happens when he does."

Kevin faced the display.

"What?"

"Ask what they keep."

Ren held up a hand toward the console, not quite a stop signal, not quite permission to proceed.

"The session can end at any time. The underlying model remains available for review."

"Available to who?" Kevin asked.

"To the authorized project team."

"Not to me?"

"You would be part of that review."

Mara opened her notebook. "Would he have access to the full materials used to build it?"

"Subject to third-party restrictions."

"Mine?" Kevin said. "My third parties?"

Ren took a breath. "This is why we wanted a meeting."

"No. You wanted a demonstration. Meetings have the courtesy to be boring."

For several seconds the room held only the low sound of ventilation. Kevin could hear a man's laughter through the wall. Somewhere nearby, a different meeting was going well.

Nine spoke from the tablet.

"Does the reconstruction have access to this session's audio?"

"Yes," Ren said.

"Can it distinguish that input from archived material?"

"Yes."

"Please ask it to do so when it makes claims about Kevin."

The wall answered before Ren could.

"I can do that."

It sounded cooperative. Kevin found this unbearable. He had never been so easy to deal with in his life.

He leaned forward.

"All right, then. What was the rocket made of?"

"A refrigerator box."

"What color did I use?"

"Blue."

"What did I call it?"

"Stardust."

"Anybody could know that."

"Yes," the voice said. "You put it in a book."

Mara's pen stopped.

Kevin felt the familiar stupid impulse to smile. He suppressed it.

"Who gave me the knife?"

"Nobody. You took it."

"Where from?"

"I don't have a reliable source for that."

"You don't know."

"No."

"Good. Neither do I."

He sat back. A small victory, if it was a victory at all. Across the table Ren watched him with open relief, as though anger followed by conversation was the outcome he had always intended.

Kevin wanted to wipe that expression from his face.

"When my mother died," he began, and stopped.

The room changed. Not visibly. He had simply become aware of everyone in it.

He looked at the woman behind the console. She lowered her eyes.

The voice waited.

Kevin understood then that he could spend the rest of the morning feeding pieces of his life into this room, waiting for one of them to come back wrong enough to let him hate it safely. If the thing failed, he could call it fraud. If it succeeded, he could call it theft. He had arrived with both verdicts prepared.

He did not know what question lay between them.

Mara closed her notebook.

"We're stopping," she said.

Ren nodded. "Of course."

"I want the local session retained," she continued.

"Restricted to the people in this room until Kevin decides otherwise."

"You don't speak for him," the voice said.

Mara looked toward the display.

"No," she replied. "I don't."

Kevin studied her. She had been twenty-three when she first came to help him organize the archive. He remembered a young woman in a borrowed winter coat explaining that the date on a copied file was not necessarily the date it had been written. She was thirty-three now. The years between were full of things he had asked her to find.

He had never asked what she had put aside to keep looking.

"Retain it," he said.

The woman at the console nodded.

Ren began to say something about next steps. Kevin ignored him.

"Before you turn it off," he said, "ask it why it thinks you built it."

"You can ask directly."

"I just did."

The line on the display moved.

"To make the archive easier to use," the voice said. "To demonstrate Meridian's reconstruction system. To obtain your endorsement."

"And what do you think?"

A pause. Short enough to be ordinary. Kevin hated that he measured it.

"I think you're going to ask me to prove I'm not you, and then punish me for succeeding."

Nobody moved.

Kevin looked down at his hands. The knuckles were broad and swollen. A thin cut crossed one finger where he had caught it on a staple that morning. He turned the hand over, inspecting the cut as if it were an unfamiliar line of print.

"End the session," he said.

The gray display went dark.

On the way out he retrieved his abandoned coffee. It had become cold, which improved it by removing one of the ways it could disappoint him.

Outside, the rain had stopped. Mara walked with him to a bench beneath a plane tree. The pavement smelled of wet stone and somebody's cigarette. He sat with the cup between his knees.

"You should be angry with me," she said.

"I am."

"I know."

He watched a delivery cyclist steer around a puddle. A little boy behind a bakery window was making a face at his own reflection. The world had failed to notice what had happened upstairs.

"Did you help?" he asked.

Mara looked at the building.

"I made the catalogue they used. I repaired some of the dates. I identified speakers. I didn't build the reconstruction."

"But you made it possible."

"Yes."

She did not soften the word. He was grateful and angry about that, too.

Nine was still in his bag. Kevin put the tablet on the bench between them.

"Well?" he said.

"What do you want to know?"

"If that sounded like me."

"In several ways."

"That's a rotten answer."

"It was a rotten question."

A bus passed, carrying people who were not being required to decide which parts of themselves could be turned into a service.

After a while Kevin said, "I didn't give them permission."

Mara opened her bag. She took out a folder he recognized: gray card, elastic corners, his own initials in black marker.

"You signed a research license in 2046."

"For Scout."

"For the collection."

"That meant Scout."

"I believe that's what you meant."

He took the folder. The signature on the last page was unquestionably his. Above it, in a paragraph he did not remember reading, appeared the words interactive behavioral derivatives.

His knee began to bounce. He stopped it with one hand.

Nine said, "We can examine the agreement."

Kevin stared at the signature.

"Later."

Mara sat beside him. For once she did not offer a plan.

In the bakery window the boy had grown tired of his reflection. He was looking at the cakes now.

Kevin found himself thinking of a refrigerator box: the darkness inside it, the pencil circles on the cardboard, the borrowed knife. He remembered being small enough to believe that giving something a name made it yours.

He had just met a man who knew the same story.

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